

46.1 Frederick's War in Italy

The foul matter was now out in the open. Pope and emperor exchanged a series of increasingly testy letters, with Frederick copying his complaints to the crowned monarchs of Europe. ("The nations are now endeavouring to despise the ruler of Italy and the imperial sceptre!" he complained, neatly conflating his differences with Gregory and his desire to put down the Lombard revolt.) Finally Frederick II, leaving troops to go on with the war in Lombardy, began to march south towards Rome itself. In August of 1241, he was approaching the city's walls when Gregory IX—well into his eighties, suffering from the heat of a Roman summer—died.[14]

Immediately, Frederick retreated and pointed out piously that his quarrel was not with the Church but with the ambitions of the man himself. Gregory's successor served for only seventeen days before dying of illness and throwing Rome into chaos. Not until 1243 was a new pope finally elected: the Genoese cardinal Sinibaldo Fieschi, a canon lawyer who now became Pope Innocent IV.

Frederick had been friendly with Cardinal Fieschi, but he had his reservations. "This election," he told his familiars, "will be of much hurt to